

Your Pelvic Floor PT Visit

Patient Information · What happens at pelvic floor physical therapy, and who it helps

WARWIKI

The pelvic floor is a group of muscles that supports the bladder, bowel and sexual organs. A pelvic floor physical therapist (PT) is trained to check and treat these muscles. The muscles may be **weak**, **too tight**, or **not working in step**. Therapy is personal, and **you are in control** of every part of it.

Who It Helps

- **Bladder:** leaks with coughing or exercise, sudden urges, trouble emptying, leakage after prostate surgery
- **Bowel:** leakage of stool or gas, or constipation when the muscles do not relax to let stool out
- **Pain:** pelvic pain, pain with sex, bladder pain, pain after childbirth or surgery
- **Prolapse:** a feeling of bulging or pressure in the vagina
- **Surgery:** some people before or after pelvic surgery. Ask your surgeon whether it will help you.

It is more than "doing Kegels." Squeezing exercises help weak muscles but can make tight, painful muscles worse. Your PT finds out which you need.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

3 in 4

women with leaks from coughing were cured or better with muscle training, vs about 1 in 10 without it

6 in 10

with bladder pain and tender muscles were much better with hands-on PT, vs 1 in 4 with massage

3 in 4

with bowel leakage had good relief with biofeedback and exercises, vs 4 in 10 with exercises alone

Numbers are averages from published studies. Serious side effects are rare. Your own results may differ.

What Happens at the First Visit

- 1 Talk.** Your symptoms, bladder and bowel habits, sex, pain, past births or surgery, and your goals. This can take most of the first visit.
- 2 Outside exam.** Posture, breathing, belly, back and hips, and how you move.
- 3 Pelvic exam, if you agree.** Muscle strength, tightness, tender spots and coordination, checked inside or from the outside.
- 4 A plan.** You leave with a first home program and a plan for your next visits.

Learn the Terms

Pelvic floor

The sling of muscles at the bottom of the pelvis.

Internal exam

A gloved finger in the vagina or rectum to check the muscles. Only with your consent.

Biofeedback

A sensor that shows your muscle activity on a screen, so you can see when you squeeze or relax.

Manual therapy

Hands-on treatment that releases tight or tender muscles and scars.

Down-training

Learning to relax muscles that stay too tight.

Dilators

Smooth rods in graded sizes that gently stretch a tight or painful vaginal opening.

Home program

Exercises and habits you practice between visits.

Do I have to have an internal exam? No. Feeling the muscles gives your PT useful information, but an internal exam is done only if it will help and only with your consent. You can say no, ask to slow down, or stop at any time, and your PT will check in with you along the way. Nothing in the exam or treatment is meant to hurt. Some first visits can even be done by video.

First visit	Follow-up visits	Every day	Weeks to months
History, exam and your first home exercises.	Treatment and a program that changes as you improve.	Practice your home program between visits.	Change builds over several sessions. Your PT reviews progress with you.

What Treatment May Include

- **Muscle training** for strength, endurance and timing, such as squeezing before you cough, sneeze or lift
- **Relaxation and breathing** to calm muscles that stay too tight
- **Hands-on therapy**, inside or outside, for tight or tender muscles and scars
- **Biofeedback** or **gentle electrical stimulation** to help you find and train the right muscles
- **Dilators** for a tight or painful vaginal opening
- **Bladder and bowel training**: calming urges, toilet posture, fluids, fiber and lifting habits

How to Get Ready

- Wear comfortable clothes. Bring a list of your medicines and any bladder diary you were asked to keep.
- Write down your goals, such as running without leaks or having sex without pain.
- Tell your PT if you are pregnant, recently gave birth, have had recent surgery or pelvic radiation, or have an infection, a wound or unexplained bleeding. Some parts of the exam may need to wait.

Tell your PT or care team if you have:

- Pain during or after treatment that does not settle
- New bleeding or unusual discharge
- Burning when you urinate, or a temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate and your bladder feels full or painful
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. Pelvic floor PT treats muscles that are weak, too tight or out of step.
2. Any internal exam is your choice, and you can stop at any time.
3. Practice your home program. Results build over weeks.